

Zakar

זָכַר

zakar – to remember. Strong's H2142.

The word appears throughout the Old Testament in law, narrative and prayer. It is ordinary rather than technical, which is where the difficulty lies: a common word carries its meaning quietly, and we supply our own.

English remembering happens in the head. Something comes back to mind, and the word is complete without anything else attached. I remembered where I had left the keys. I remembered that it was her birthday, and did nothing about it.

Zakar carries on into conduct. The remembering shows up as something done, and the doing is how you can tell it happened. When the Old Testament says somebody remembered, the question is not what came to mind but what changed.

WHERE PEOPLE ARE THE SUBJECT

Remember the Sabbath day, to keep it holy. Israel is not being asked to have the day come to mind on the day. They are being asked to stop working.

You shall remember that you were a slave in the land of Egypt. In Deuteronomy this is attached to conduct every time it appears –

therefore keep the Sabbath, therefore release your servant, therefore leave the sheaf in the field. Not nostalgia. The reason for behaving a particular way towards somebody with nothing.

Joseph asks the cupbearer to remember him. The cupbearer is restored, and the text says he did not remember Joseph, but forgot him. He had not mislaid the information. He was in the one place where a word from him would have counted, and said nothing.

WHERE GOD IS THE SUBJECT

God remembered Noah and all the beasts and all the livestock that were with him in the ark. What follows immediately is wind over the water and the waters going down. Nothing suggests Noah had slipped his mind. The remembering is the point at which the account turns from rising water to receding water.

God heard their groaning, and God remembered his covenant with Abraham, with Isaac, and with Jacob. The exodus has not begun. This is where it begins.

And God remembered Rachel, and God listened to her and opened her womb. The same construction on the smallest scale. One woman, one household.

In none of these does the text say God recalled something he had lost track of. What it reports is a change in the situation, and it names that change *remembering*. Before it, a condition that has gone on too long. After it, movement.

WHAT HE REMEMBERS

Covenant, more than anything else. The bow in the cloud (Genesis 9:15–16). The groaning in Egypt (Exodus 2:24, 6:5). The scattered people under judgement (Leviticus 26:42, 45). A thousand generations (Psalm 105:8, 111:5). *Berit* is a formal word – an agreement with terms, the sort of thing that could be read aloud in a court.

People, by name. Noah. Abraham. Rachel. Hannah. Samson, once, at the end.

What we are made of. He remembered that they were but flesh (Psalm 78:39). He remembers that we are dust (Psalm 103:14). Both times the remembering is why the judgement does not run its full course.

His own hesed. Once – Psalm 98:3. The warm word standing where the formal one usually stands. He remembers Israel's *hesed* once as well, in Jeremiah 2:2, but that is their loyalty to him rather than his to them.

THE VERB REVERSED

I will not remember your sins (Isaiah 43:25). I will remember their sin no more (Jeremiah 31:34). None of the transgressions that he has committed shall be remembered against him (Ezekiel 18:22).

Read with English remembering in mind, these sound like forgetfulness – as though God mislays the record. But *zakar* was never about the contents of the mind. It is a decision about conduct. He knows exactly what was done. He will not act on it.

So the verb runs both ways and does the same thing in each direction.

What he remembers, he acts on. What he refuses to remember, he refuses

to act on.

Psalm 25 has both, six verses apart. Remember your mercy, O LORD, and your steadfast love (v. 6). Remember not the sins of my youth or my transgressions (v. 7).

IN SHORT

The question to bring to *zakar* is never what somebody has in mind. It is what they are going to do.

The asymmetry between asking God to remember his *hesed* and the text reporting that he has is taken up in a companion article, [What God Remembers](#).

This article did not begin with artificial intelligence. It began with years of ministry, reading, prayer, suffering, and conversation.

During its development, AI became a conversation partner. It challenged assumptions, tested arguments, suggested structures, and helped refine expression. Many of the words here emerged through that dialogue.

The experiences, convictions, interpretations, and conclusions remain my own.